

Designer Notes

Back in 2011, after having played several of the VPG *States of Siege* games - *Lost Cause* and *We Must Tell the Emperor* among them - I noted that the system was predominantly designed for grand sweeps of history, often spanning many years, or even centuries, at a high level of abstraction. So I got to wondering: "Could this game system be scaled down to the operational level?". The result I believe is yes, hence *Normandy: The Bloody Pocket*, which I hope will be the first of a number of titles, adapting this great solitaire system to operational level campaigns.

The prototype was duly completed, using scissors, a printer and glue, and the rulebook sent over to Alan Emrich and John Welch at VPG. The feedback was very positive, but then I needed to test the game to its limits.

Sadly, at that point, work and family commitments got in the way, and the demise of VPG meant that the project got left for 15 years, until now.

Having seen the rejuvenation of interest in the series, with reprints of *Ottoman Sunset* and *Hapsburg Eclipse*, among others, in addition to great new games from Ben Madison, and the David Kennedy substack (SoS), now that I have a bit more time on my hands I wondered if I couldn't revisit the game. Luckily I found all the old electronic files in my email outbox so I was able to redo all the artwork by using the old material as a starting point.

Well, 15 years on and AI is there to help with creating the graphics for a prototype, which I put into *TableTop Simulator* and *Vassal*, and, voila, we have a game!

So what were the design considerations?

First and foremost, I wanted the game to model two things that aren't always evident in WW2 simulations: i) Hitler's interference in operational matters, and ii) the correct employment of reserves.

Second, it needed to play fast, around 2 hours max. Like many, I no longer seem to have the attention span to play solitaire games (or any games) for hours on end. I wanted it to be quick and also give the player as many decisions each turn as possible.

Thirdly, it needed to model the situation in Normandy as accurately as possible, especially from the German perspective; you can hold the Allies very effectively for the first half of the campaign, but your position will quickly deteriorate thereafter. This was the historical dynamic I was looking for.

So how does the game play out?

At first, things will seem fairly comfortable; the Allies will make little progress, and there are plenty of opportunities for German counter-attacks. In fact, if a lot of German reinforcements appear too early you can feel like you have too much strength. That can be as dangerous as the opposite, where the Allied offensives occur earlier than is common.

This is where avoiding over-committing reserves too soon, despite the temptation, can be the difference between victory and defeat.

Early on, there will be opportunities to rotate panzer formations out of the line for refit, add actions to the reserve and possibly even build some Fortified Villages. But, alas, that situation will not persist.

By the second half of the game, losses are starting to have a major effect; resources, especially fuel, are running low, Hitler is getting increasingly grumpy (and, increasingly, interfering with operational matters) and there simply aren't enough actions each turn to do everything that needs to be done.

The situation, as it progresses towards the end of the game, will become increasingly desperate, especially once Patton's 3rd US Army is activated and all the Allied Armies are upgraded.

The opportunities for counter-attack diminish, not least for lack of oil, and the Allied advance will start to seem unstoppable. As the defeats and retreats increase in frequency, the game becomes a balancing act between holding the Allies back and, at the same time, trying to avoid being relieved of command by Hitler. This becomes even more problematic following the Assassination attempt on Hitler (if that occurs in the early part of the game, a tough job just became tougher.)

All that creates a certain tension in the game. And that is what I was striving for.

A word on the siege mechanic in the game. It felt right but after many playthroughs I just couldn't be sure that for different levels of defense, the sieges (especially of Caen), were within historical parameters for both duration and rate of German casualties.

So I decided to write a test engine in python and run the siege of Caen literally one million times, for all levels of defense, and with the help of my wife, who is a professional modeler (in an economics domain), I was able to deduce that the siege mechanic is giving – on average - historically plausible results, but with quite a degree of variation, which I think is perfect for a game.

My intent is to use the Monte-Carlo simulation approach (the name for this statistical analysis) in other settings as it has the potential to really help with playtesting.

Enjoy the game!

